Deconstructing Gender-Based Peer Exclusion in Primary Schools

TOGETHER!

Behavioral Research | Role: UX Researcher | Timeline: 6 weeks

Designing a non-coercive classroom ritual kit to dismantle early gender segregation before childhood biases harden into adult behavior.

Project Objective

To decode the psychological and environmental triggers behind playground gender segregation, & design a lightweight, non-coercive intervention that normalizes voluntary mixed-gender collaboration.

The Target Window
Children Aged 8-12

Secondary Research

Children avoid mixing because early gender schemas, stereotype threats & institutionalized biases silently teach them that boys & girls belong apart.

- By ages 8-12, exclusion becomes automatic, not intentional.
- Childhood segregation shapes adult professional patterns, fueling workplace bias, communication friction, & unequal collaboration later in life.
- Parents unknowingly reinforce gender roles through daily tasks & language

Research Question

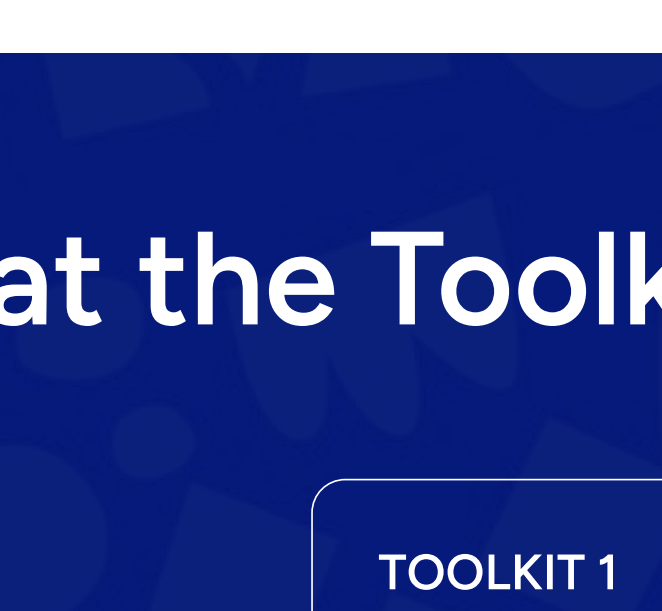
Under what social, environmental, and psychological conditions do boys and girls (ages 8–12) feel safe enough to engage in mixed-gender collaboration, instead of defaulting to exclusion?

Behavioral Hypothesis

Children do not avoid the opposite gender because of dislike, but because of fear of peer judgement; reducing social sanctions will unlock their willingness to collaborate.

Research Progression

How Each Study Improved the Next

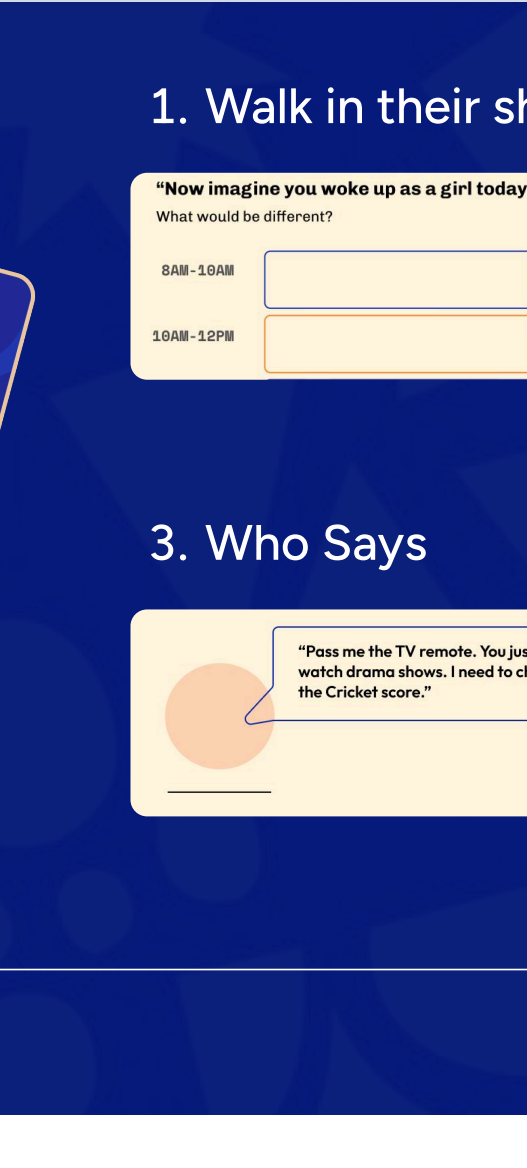


	Observational Study	Individual Generative Toolkit	Individual Diary Study
	9 Participants MITID Evening School	36 Participants Army Public school	14 Participants Take-home Booklets
FOCUS	Mapped organic body language, physical hesitation, and spontaneous play grouping.	Comic strips and story completions to probe collective peer norms.	Individual private booklets completed over 3 days to remove group peer pressure entirely
GAP FOUND	Observed avoidance, but couldn't tell why kids were staying apart.	In group settings, dominant kids policed answers, needed private honest reflections.	Breakthrough: When peer pressure was removed, children admitted they wanted to interact, but feared teasing

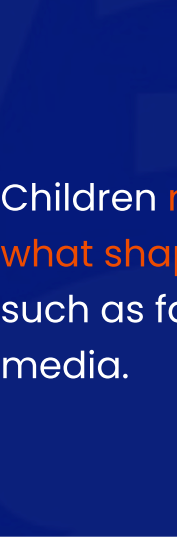
But what is influencing these beliefs?

What the Toolkits contained

TOOLKIT 1

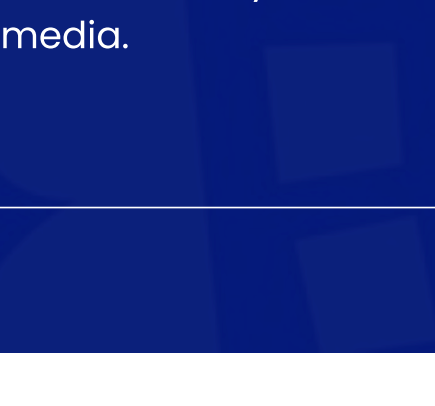

Name:
Age:
Date:
Are you a
☐Girl ☐Boy
Draw your stick figure
For all of these comic strips, draw and complete the rest of stories!
1. The bell rang for recess. The boys ran to the cricket pitch, but they saw the girls were already standing there holding the bat.
2. What are they arguing about? Fill the text boxes and complete the story.
3. A strange sound is coming from inside... what happens next?
Oooo...

Comic Strip Completion Sheets



Children are given a short comic showing a situation, with two empty frames & asked to draw what happens next

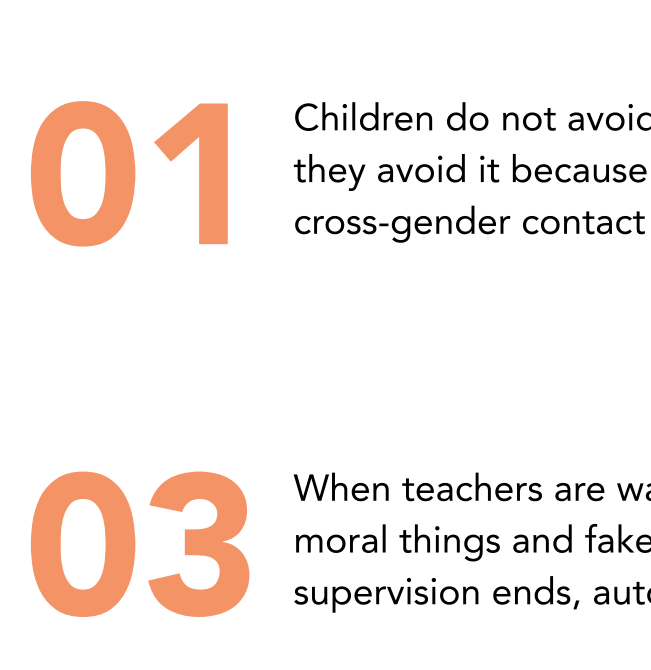
Story Completion



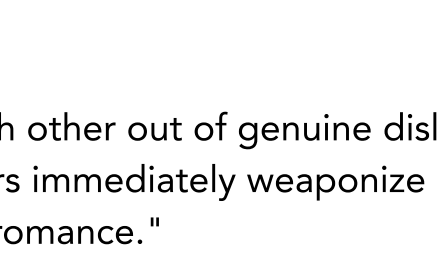
Shivani had been disruptive during class, and when the teacher finally corrected her, the boys started saying...

A set of short, open-ended story starters involving everyday social dilemmas, are read aloud in a round group

TOOLKIT 2


Learning Differently
Learning Differently
Name:
Age:

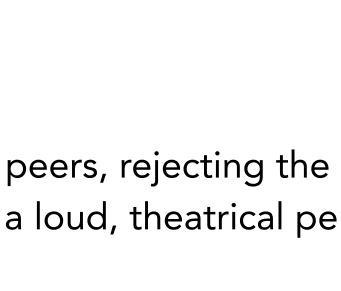
1. Walk in their shoes



"Now imagine you woke up as a girl today."
What would be different?
8AM-10AM
10AM-12PM

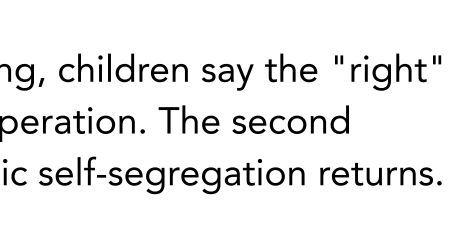
Children describe what they think a day in the life of the other gender looks like

2. Scenarios



Children explain why certain social situations happen, like teasing or exclusion.

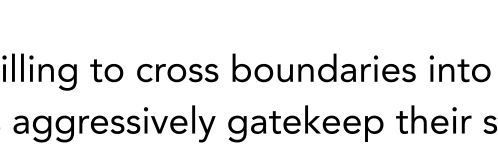
3. Who Says



"Pass me the TV remote. You just watch drama shows. I need to check the Cricket score."

Children name who or what shapes their beliefs, such as family, friends, or media.

4. Media Diet



4 In attitude/sigma edits, being rude to girls is shown as "power"

Children circle the things they watch & then select the emoji based on if they think a situation is cringe/cool.

Key Insights

01 Children do not avoid each other out of genuine dislike; they avoid it because peers immediately weaponize cross-gender contact as "romance."

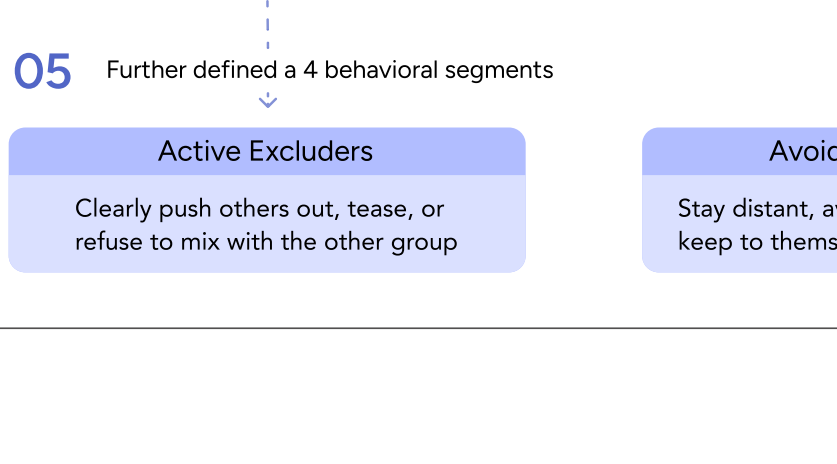
02 In front of peers, rejecting the opposite gender is rarely quiet, it is a loud, theatrical performance.

03 When teachers are watching, children say the "right" moral things and fake cooperation. The second supervision ends, automatic self-segregation returns.

04 Girls are often willing to cross boundaries into boys' games, but boys aggressively gatekeep their spaces to defend status.

Analysis & Patterns

01 All the behaviours observed across all 3 studies were tabulated.



100+ entires

02 Each behaviour was marked against the setting in which it appeared & segmented by Identities.

SETTINGS CONSIDERED
Supervised | Unsupervised | Mixed group
Boys only group | Girls only group

Unsupervised	Boys only Group	Boys Girls Mixed Group
		x
		x
x		x
x		x

03 Behaviours that co-occurred were grouped into 9 themes.

- 01. Boundary Maintenance & Social Exclusion
- 02. Social Withdrawal
- 03. Norm Compliance & Rule Alignment
- 04. Consent, Fairness & Moral Regulation
- 05. Role Negotiation & Power Positioning
- 06. Gender Role Rigidity
- 07. Social Belonging & Acceptance Seeking
- 08. Collaborative Problem-Solving
- 09. Gender Role Flexibility & Adaptation

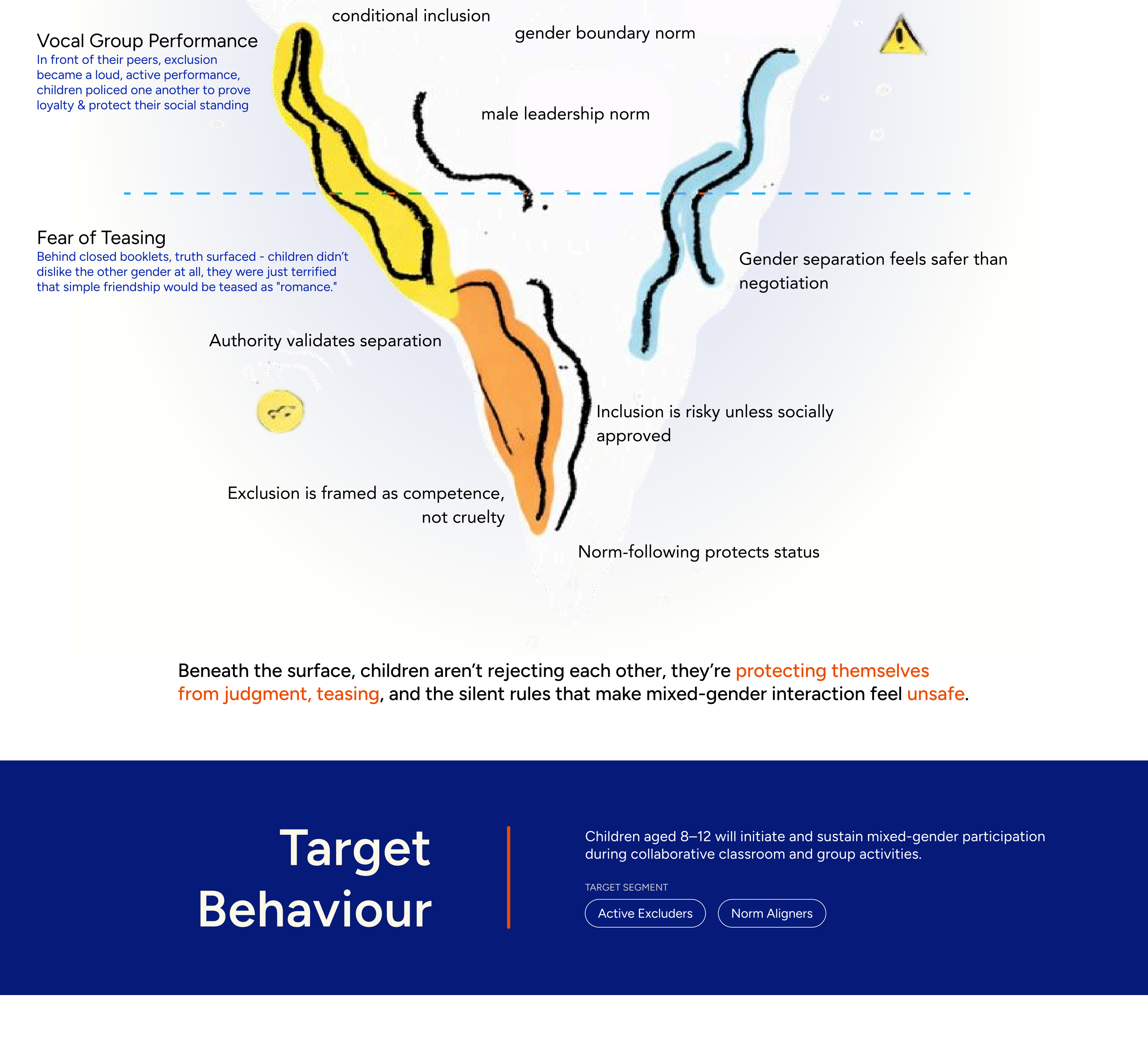
04 Themes with the same root motivation were group together

05 Further defined a 4 behavioral segments

Exclusion	Withdrawal	Compliance	Collaboration
Maintaining boundaries, control & in-group dominance	Reducing social risk through disengagement or invisibility	Achieving safety & acceptance through alignment with norms	Maximising shared success through flexibility & mutuality
Active Excluders	**Avoidant Separators**	**Norm Aligners**	**Flexible Collaborators**
Clearly push others out, tease, or refuse to mix with the other group	Stay distant, avoid direct interaction, & keep to themselves to reduce social risk	Act based on rules or adult presence & avoid standing out or challenging norms	Interact with the other side, are open to share, take consent & collaborate together

Iceberg Model

With every research tool, we moved from what children are conditioned by, to how they act in public, down to what they secretly feel in private.


no eye contact
avoiding direct interaction
refusal to sit/pair
physical distancing
taunting/mocking opposite gender
Verbal Unacceptance of opposite gender
reduced engagement in mixed groups
reduced coordination in mixed groups
competence based inclusion
context Facilitated segregation
stronger exclusion in group setting
automatic self segregation
social policing
observation effect
conditional inclusion
gender boundary norm
male leadership norm
Gender separation feels safer than negotiation
Authority validates separation
Inclusion is risky unless socially approved
Exclusion is framed as competence, not cruelty
Norm-following protects status

Systemic Conditioning
School routines, seating arrangements, & adult language quietly normalized division long before children ever started enforcing it themselves

Physical Hesitation
In plain sight, children showed immediate physical hesitation: avoiding eye contact, freezing up, & instinctively retreating to same-gender comfort zones

Vocal Group Performance
In front of their peers, exclusion became a loud, active performance, children policed one another to prove loyalty & protect their social standing

Fear of Teasing
Behind closed booklets, truth surfaced - children didn't dislike the other gender at all, they were just terrified that simple friendship would be teased as "romance."

Beneath the surface, children aren't rejecting each other, they're protecting themselves from judgment, teasing, and the silent rules that make mixed-gender interaction feel unsafe.

Target Behaviour

Children aged 8–12 will initiate and sustain mixed-gender participation during collaborative classroom and group activities.

TARGET SEGMENT
Active Excluders | Norm Aligners

Pressure Map

Pressure to enforce group norms
Fitting in gives emotional safety
High visibility of cross-gender mixing

Children aged 8–12 will initiate and sustain mixed-gender participation during collaborative classroom and group activities

Task requires cross-gender collaboration
Competitive motivation / winning
When a popular kid includes, others follow

Better together. Stronger always.
TOGETHER!
Better together. Stronger always.
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Better together. Stronger always.

TOGETHER!

Together is a teacher's toolkit of behaviour building rituals and activities that gradually reshape how children interact with the opposite gender.

Why?

By ages 8-12, exclusion becomes automatic, and no one questions it. We try to reverse this. Inclusion becomes automatic and no one questions it.

What?

A lightweight teacher toolkit of daily, weekly, and monthly rituals that make mixed-gender interaction rule-based, repeated, and normal.

How?

A box with three compartments. Teacher opens the right one, assigns pairs by color dot, flips the timer. The ritual runs itself. No prep, no training, no extra class time.

Toolkit Box

- Three compartments: Daily, Weekly, Monthly
- Activity cards, sticker seals, role-assignment stickers
- One-page teacher instruction sheet inside the lid

+

Ritual Design

- 5 daily rituals repeated across the week
- 4 weekly rituals that build familiarity over time
- 1 monthly ritual that marks progress and creates shared memory

Together Teacher's Manual

What's Inside the Kits?

The kit is one box with three compartments, Daily, Weekly & Monthly. Each compartment holds everything needed for that ritual cycle, ready to use straight out of the box.

Daily

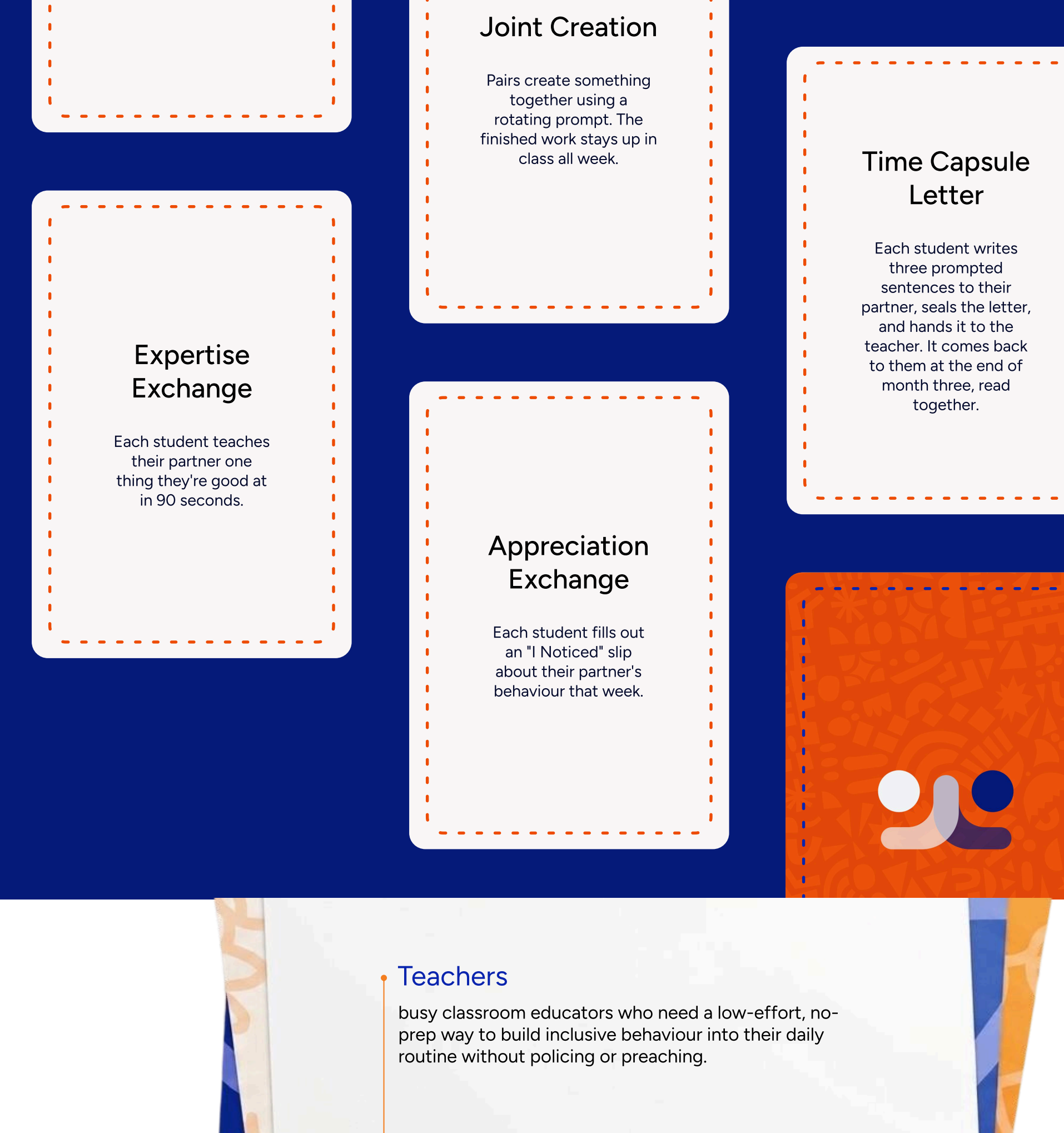
Pairs complete a short 3–5 minute activity that's been specifically designed to lower social pressure and make interaction feel low-stakes, even fun.

Weekly

They go a little deeper teaching each other something, building something together, solving something for each other. And once a month.

Monthly

A simple Time Capsule exchange that quietly builds long-term emotional connection through one guided activity each month.



Telephone Tap
Person A draws an image on Person B's back. Person B guesses.

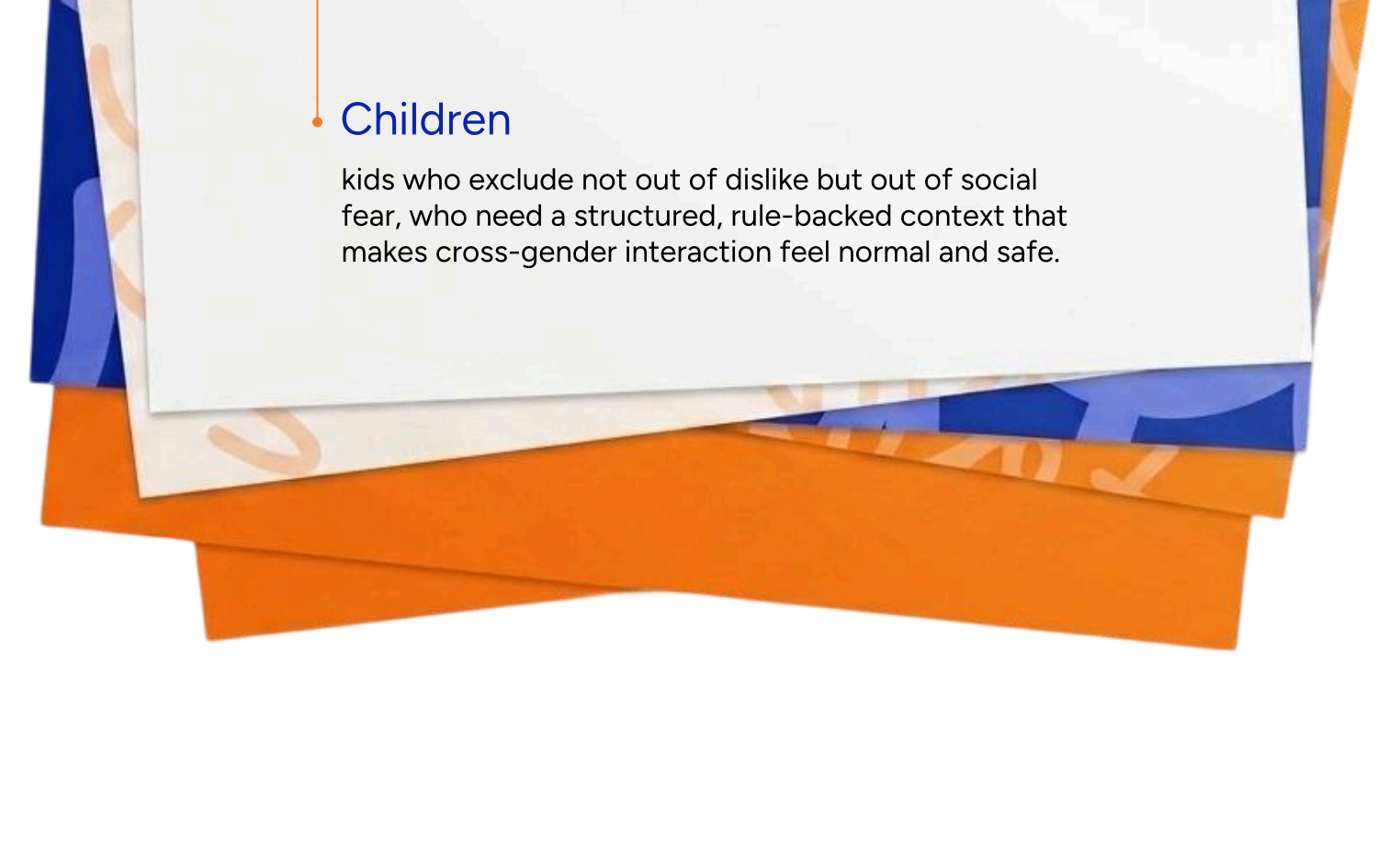
Expertise Exchange
Each student teaches their partner one thing they're good at in 90 seconds.

Joint Creation
Pairs create something together using a rotating prompt. The finished work stays up in class all week.

Appreciation Exchange
Each student fills out an "I Noticed" slip about their partner's behaviour that week.

Time Capsule Letter
Each student writes three prompted sentences to their partner, seals the letter, and hands it to the teacher. It comes back to them at the end of month three, read together.

Who uses the kit?



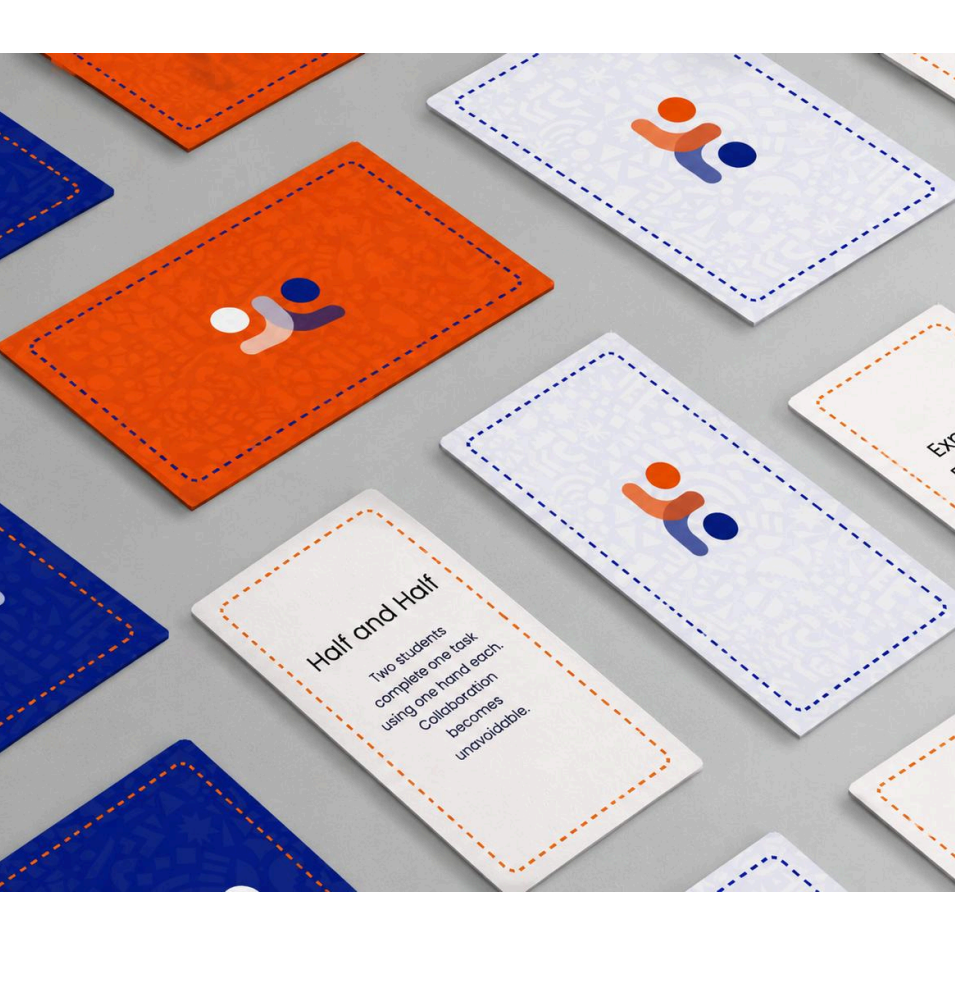
Teachers
busy classroom educators who need a low-effort, no-prep way to build inclusive behaviour into their daily routine without policing or preaching.

Children
kids who exclude not out of dislike but out of social fear, who need a structured, rule-backed context that makes cross-gender interaction feel normal and safe.

Intervention Entry Point

First 3–5 minutes of the school day or class transitions.

The moment before a lesson begins when children are settling in and self-segregation happens naturally.


Hold and Hold

Pressure Shifts

Removes the need for any child to personally choose to include the rule decides, not the child. Converts inclusion from a social risk into a classroom routine. Activates peer leadership when a dominant child follows the ritual, others follow.

Success Metrics

- Mixed-gender pairs maintained without resistance
- Roles followed without pushback
- Teacher enforcement reduces week on week
- Mixed-gender grouping begins appearing outside the ritual
- Both students contributing actively during paired tasks